

Psalms 49

None Can Redeem

None of them can... redeem his brother

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Hear this, all ye people; give ear, all ye inhabitants of the world:*
- 2 *Both low and high, rich and poor, together.*
- 3 *My mouth shall speak of wisdom; and the meditation of my heart shall be of understanding.*
- 4 *I will incline mine ear to a parable: I will open my dark saying upon the harp.*
- 5 *Wherefore should I fear in the days of evil, when the iniquity of my heels shall compass me about?*
- 6 *They that trust in their wealth, and boast themselves in the multitude of their riches;*
- 7 *None of them can by any means redeem his brother, nor give to God a ransom for him:*
- 8 *(For the redemption of their soul is precious, and it ceaseth for ever:)*
- 9 *That he should still live for ever, and not see corruption.*
- 10 *For he seeth that wise men die, likewise the fool and the brutish person perish, and leave their wealth to others.*
- 11 *Their inward thought is, that their houses shall continue for ever, and their dwelling places to all generations; they call their lands after their own names.*
- 12 *Nevertheless man being in honour abideth not: he is like the beasts that perish.*
- 13 *This their way is their folly: yet their posterity approve their sayings. Selah.*
- 14 *Like sheep they are laid in the grave; death shall feed on them; and the upright shall have dominion over them in the morning; and their beauty shall consume in the grave from their dwelling.*
- 15 *But God will redeem my soul from the power of the grave: for he shall receive me. Selah.*
- 16 *Be not thou afraid when one is made rich, when the glory of his house is increased;*
- 17 *For when he dieth he shall carry nothing away: his glory shall not descend after him.*
- 18 *Though while he lived he blessed his soul: and men will praise thee, when thou doest well to thyself.*
- 19 *He shall go to the generation of his fathers; they shall never see light.*
- 20 *Man that is in honour, and understandeth not, is like the beasts that perish.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalms 49 is a wisdom psalm addressed to all peoples—low and high, rich and poor alike—confronting the folly of trusting in wealth, since riches cannot purchase redemption from death. The wise and the foolish perish alike and leave their wealth behind them, while the psalmist expresses trust that God will redeem his own soul from the power of the grave. The psalm moves beyond mere moralizing about mortality into a genuine, if brief, hope of resurrection beyond death.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

A call to all peoples, low and high, rich and poor together, to hear; the psalmist's mouth will speak wisdom and his heart understanding, inclining his ear to a parable and opening a dark saying upon the harp.

Verse 5-9

Why fear in days of evil when surrounded by iniquity? Those who trust in wealth and boast in riches cannot redeem a brother or give God a ransom for him; the redemption of a soul is costly and ceases forever, for no one can live forever and escape corruption.

Verse 10-12

He sees wise men die, and fools and brutish men perish alike, leaving their wealth to others; their inward thought is that their houses will continue forever, named after themselves, yet man does not abide in honor—he is like the beasts that perish.

Verse 13-15

This is the folly of their way, yet their descendants approve their sayings; like sheep they are laid in the grave, death shall feed on them, and the upright will have dominion over them in the morning, their beauty consumed in the grave far from any dwelling. But God will redeem the psalmist's soul from the power of the grave, for He will receive him.

Verse 16-20

Do not be afraid when someone grows rich or when the glory of his house increases, for he will carry nothing away when he dies—his glory will not descend after him. Though he blesses his own soul in life and is praised when he does well for himself, he will go to the generation of his fathers and never again see light; the person without understanding is like the beasts that perish.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Wealth, however impressive, has no power over death and cannot purchase redemption for anyone, including its owner; this reality should quiet both envy of the rich and fear of the powerful. God’s redemption of the soul from the grave, briefly but genuinely glimpsed here, is something wealth simply cannot offer and only He can provide.

Application for life today.

When intimidated or envious of someone’s wealth or status, remember concretely that “he shall carry nothing away when he dieth” (v. 17). Examine whether your own sense of security rests more on financial cushion than on the God who alone redeems the soul from the grave. Let verse 15’s brief flash of resurrection hope encourage you that death, even for the psalmist under the old covenant, was not understood as the final word for those God receives.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where do you find yourself fearing or envying wealth and power in a way this psalm directly corrects?

2. What would change in your financial decisions or anxieties if you fully believed “he shall carry nothing away” (v. 17)?

3. How does the psalmist’s confidence that “God will redeem my soul” (v. 15) shape your own hope beyond death?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).